This is reflected in how the NLD presents the violence in Rakhine. Sometimes it argues that it is an unfortunate side effect of the move to democracy, in which long-suppressed tensions can come to the surface. In other instances they are willing to declare, 'The Rohingyas are not our citizens'.[62] Equally, while the NLD has a long history of collaboration with the ALD/RNDP/ANP within Rakhine, in 2015 it found itself in electoral competition with them as it sought to maximise its vote outside Burman ethnic areas. Perhaps to its frustration, it found that its old allies in the RNDP/ANP were now seeking to portray the NLD as pro-Muslim simply because it stood up to some of the worst of the recent legislation (and that on the basis of women's rights, not discrimination against non-Buddhist communities). Equally, as noted earlier, the NLD has lost the backing of the MaBaTha over this stance.

Other risks

Even if the 2015 electoral cycle passes without significant violence against the Rohingyas, the simple reality is they have been pushed to the margins of life in Myanmar. The last vestiges of civic engagement have been stripped away in the course of the 2015 election campaign at a national level, and powerful regional politicians vie with each other as to who can produce the most extreme statements.

The most likely risk after the electoral cycle is complete is of a renewed refugee crisis,[63] but there are other potential triggers for further violence. One is the possibility of acts of terrorism and another is the impact of a new major natural or health-based disaster.

A new refugee crisis

At the moment, it is clear that only two things are preventing a renewal of the outpouring of refugees from earlier in 2015. Some Rohingyas are still hoping for positive changes in the aftermath of the elections, but for many it is a case of waiting until the seas are calm enough to cross.[64] In October 2014, it was estimated that some 13,000 Rohingyas fled by way of the sea, and there is every reason to believe that this time the number will be much higher. Many are now determined to join relatives who fled in earlier